

Two principles

01 Freedom through obedience

A dog that will recall, settle and walk on a loose lead is a dog that gets to come with you. Obedience is not about control — it is what buys a dog its liberty.

02 Treat the cause, not the symptom

A dog barks, then growls, then shows its teeth, and only then bites. Punish the growl and the growling stops — but the fear is untouched, and the next time there is no warning at all.

A balanced approach, said plainly rather than hidden behind a label. No two dogs arrive with the same history of what has paid off for them, so the plan is built for the dog in front of me.

Correction is reserved for behaviours with real safety consequences. Nuisance habits are better solved by changing the setup — reaching for correction on those is both unkind and ineffective.



Bluegum Canine

BEHAVIOUR PRACTICE

Twenty years with dogs, formalised in December 2026 with a Master Trainer certificate from the Highland Canine School for Dog Trainers, North Carolina — a six-month residential programme, 960 hours across 34 modules.

Taught by Jason Purgason, the school's primary instructor and current President of the International Association of Canine Professionals. Full member of the IACP since 2025.

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SERVING

Sligo, and a long way past it

Fully insured · a written plan after every consultation · an honest assessment, always



Bluegum Canine

Calm, methodical training for dogs that have to live in the real world.

Walks you enjoy, a recall you can trust, and a dog that can come with you.

Most dogs have far more in them than their owners expect — including the ones who have tried before.



CO. SLIGO, IRELAND

WHERE MOST PEOPLE START

If you have already tried

Most of the dogs I see are not a first attempt. Their owners have read the books, watched the videos, and very often worked with a trainer already. That is a good place to start from — it usually means the groundwork is there and something specific is missing.

Advice that works beautifully for one dog can do very little for another.

WHAT PEOPLE USUALLY RING ABOUT

01 **Pulling on the lead**
Walks that are a battle, not a pleasure.

02 **Barking and lunging at other dogs**
The most common call I get.

03 **Nervous around people**
Shrinking, barking or hiding when visitors call.

04 **Poor recall**
A dog you dare not let off the lead.

05 **Guarding food or toys**
Growling over the bowl, stiff over a toy.

Every one of these is workable.

And no dog is too old to learn

Learning does not stop with age. Older dogs take on new behaviour perfectly well, given the steps in order.

SERVICES OFFERED

How I can help

01 **Puppy foundations**
Socialisation, handling and good habits early.

02 **Everyday obedience**
Recall, settle, loose lead — earned freedom.

03 **Behaviour consultation**
Reactivity, aggression, anxiety, livestock worrying.

04 **One-to-one sessions**
At your home, or on ground of your choosing.

05 **Residential training**
Board-and-train, for a proper run at it.

ONE THING THAT EXPLAINS A LOT

Dogs cope well with always. They cope well with never. They cope very badly with sometimes.

A great deal of training that stalls is really a household that has not yet agreed the rules. We sort the people out first, and the dog usually follows without much argument.



THE STEPPED APPROACH

Four steps

Every behaviour goes through the same four steps. Skip one and it will not hold.

01 **Teaching**
What the behaviour is. Should take the longest; most often rushed.

02 **Reinforcing**
Consistent consequences, until it is reliable not optional.

03 **Proofing**
Distance, duration and distraction, until it holds anywhere.

04 **Maintaining**
Keeping it there. This is where I teach you, not the dog.

HOW IT WORKS

01 **We talk on the phone first.**

02 **I assess your dog where the behaviour happens.**

03 **You get a written plan, and support while you work it.**

TWO THINGS I WILL SAY EARLY

Health before behaviour. A sudden change with no obvious cause goes to your vet before it comes to me.

It often looks worse before it looks better. A behaviour on its way out tends to spike first — that is where most people give up.